

Steely presence: Col. Ashok (centre, facing page) officiated the high-voltage clash between Algeria's Imane Khelif and Hungary's Luca Anna Hamori. GETTYIMAGES

screens to show live telecasts of the matches, and with the crowds reacting to every moment, the whole of Paris turned into a large stadium. Even though the USA showcased its dominance, it did not affect the French people's love for their teams.

Y. B. Sarangi

Winning by pin

One of the traditions of the Olympic Games is the collection and exchange of pins. Before the Games begin, representatives from all countries — athletes, coaches, administrators, and even journalists — are given official pins.

Wherever you go, there are almost always volunteers who collect and exchange the pins they already possess for those from countries that they don't already have.

They often stick these pins on the ribbons of their accreditation cards. By the end of the Games, the ribbons are adorned with pins from a wide variety of countries.

One pin that seems particularly hard to get is that of India. Many volunteers from the country say that they have requested pins from the Indian administrators who are part of the Indian contingent, but they have been told that none are available.

The few pins that this journalist collected were given by athletes and coaches and were then exchanged for pins from athletes and coaches of other countries.

Perhaps his most prized pin was one from Cuba. It was originally given to Manu Bhaker, but the 22-year-old has a tradition of not accepting any gifts before a competition.

Her coach, Jaspal Rana, passed the pin to this journalist. Manu went on to win two Olympic bronze medals — a more than suitable exchange policy.

Jonathan Selvaraj



Local support on point: When France took on the USA in both the men's and women's finals during the last two days of the Games, big crowds gathered not only at the venues but also restaurants, cafes, and bars across the city to support their teams. GETTYIMAGES



Pin of fortune: Before the Games get underway, the representatives of all countries — athletes, coaches, administrators and even journalists — are given official pins. RITU RAJ KONWAR